

"OPERATION

The Pentagon's Secret Campaign to Harass, Humiliate, and Hound Out of the Military those Officers and Men Who Dare to Talk About UFOs!

Richard N. Bauers died of a heart attack in Cincinnati last year. Some of us who had served with him in the Air Force convened to lay him to his final rest and Dick was interred in a flag-draped casket on a wet green Ohio hillside, on a brooding, murky afternoon. It was like the afternoon we'd hit the Thai Nguyen steel works with field-sweep radar from the SAM sites tracking us all the way from the coast.

A bugler from the Ohio National Guard blew taps. **RICHARD N. BAUERS, 1939-1977**, the grave stone says. No mention of the Air Force career which so consumed Dick that he never married. Dick had been axed in the Air Force's cutback of flying personnel after Vietnam—as a captain. He should have been a lieutenant colonel, active, and en route to where a lot of us had expected him to end up—as Chief of Staff.

Dick Bauers liked the Air Force, women, flying, Irish coffee, handball, and old jazz. He was a complicated man with a colorful life. So it might be an exaggeration to say that he was hounded out of the Air Force,—and to his death,—because he had spotted a UFO and spoken out about it.

It can't be documented that Dick's concern over UFOs led to his being "selected out" of the service, and the Air Force denies this.

But try to convince his brother, Jim. "In my opinion, there was a conscious effort to ruin Dick because he refused to keep quiet about the UFO that behaved in a hostile manner toward him and his aircraft."

James P. Bauers, 42, a Washington, D.C., contracts specialist, is a cool-mannered and conservative family man who doesn't make serious charges

lightly and isn't interested in mounting a "crusade" in his brother's behalf.

"I'm not going to run around with a chip on my shoulder about this thing. I'm simply saying what I know. Dick spotted a flying saucer and felt there was some possibility—only a possibility—that it might be a spacecraft flown by intelligent beings. He was told to keep quiet about it and wouldn't. So they harassed him, and when that didn't work they tried to make him look foolish. There was a programmed effort to ridicule Dick and it probably influenced the OER's (evaluation reports) that got him drummed out of the service."

UFO researchers have long believed that the Pentagon is running an "Operation Ridicule" intended to discredit men who speak out about UFOs. "Operation Ridicule" does more than impose a lid of silence on UFO sightings. It ruins reputations, wrecks careers, destroys human beings.

The notion that the top brass are out to "get" men who talk about flying saucers was first suggested in the early 1950's by UFO writer Maj. Donald Keyhoe. Pilots sent to intercept strange intruders told Keyhoe they were warned, afterward, to keep quiet about what they saw and did. Anyone who didn't was assigned to a dreary supply-depot job, low-ranked by promotion boards, and "selected out" of the service.

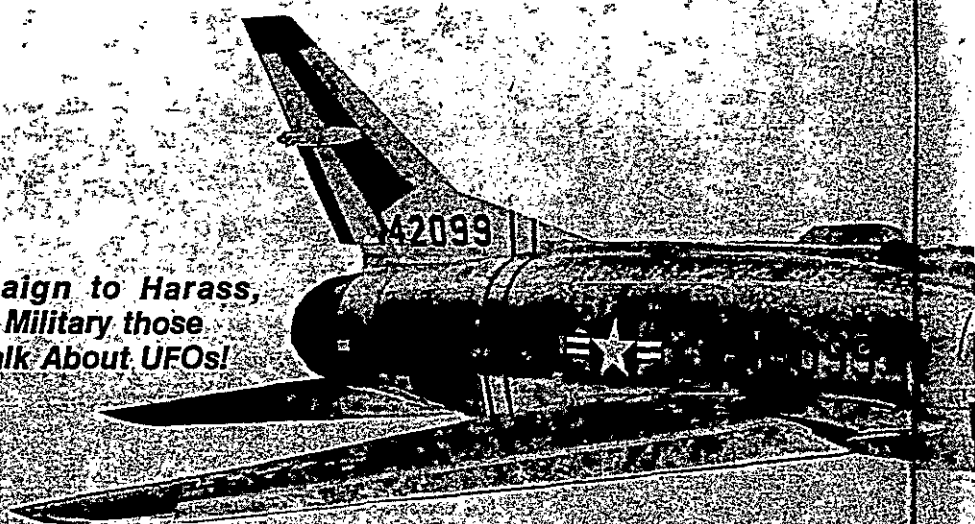
Long before Dick Bauers' death fo-

cused the problem in my mind, my own UFO research had led me to other servicemen who knew of "Operation Ridicule" and feared it. At least a dozen officers, over the years, confirmed in private what they couldn't say in public. As a Strategic Air Command officer at Pease Air Force Base, New Hampshire, put it: "There are directives telling commanders how to put the pressure on guys who try to get the public, press, or Congress interested in UFOs. The word is out: If you want to protect your hide, you'll file a secret report when you spot a UFO, not keep a copy, and never breathe a word about it to anybody."

For Capt. Richard N. Bauers, the UFO awakening took place on the cold, clear night of Dec. 11, 1972, a few miles north of Fayetteville, N.C. "Awakening is the word," Dick told me later. "Until that time, I never took flying saucers seriously. Lots of guys had seen them. But the brass claimed they were weather balloons or hallucinations. I thought they really were."

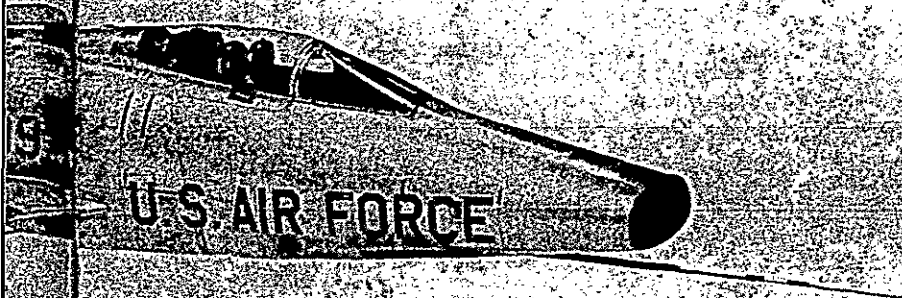
Bauers was at the controls of an F-100 Super Sabre at 43,000 feet when Pope Air Force Base, near Fayetteville, told him he had traffic nearby. "They said somebody was tagging me, flying without a flight plan, and without a working transponder. The suggestion was, some private pilot had blundered into my area without proper clearance. The only problem was—private pilots didn't fly at that altitude."

Bauers glanced back to his right and spotted a murky red glow, something



RIDICULE

By Rufus Drake



without a distinct shape, just behind him. He banked to the right and dipped a wing.

The red glow emanated from a large flying object which had been hidden from his view by his own wingtip. The object was circular, about the size of his F-100—a perfect disc, seemingly metal-skinned, with a corrugated seam running around its edge—and it gave off a reddish glow that seemed to form a halo around it.

Bauers did a double take. He saw no other distinguishing features. No port-holes, no antenna, no propulsion outlets. He knew! He never doubted, not for an instant. This was one of those UFOs everybody was talking about it!

Suddenly, tensed-up, wary, Dick Bauers deepened the angle of his bank and threw his jet into a sharp turn to the right.

The object followed him!

His conversation with Pope Air Force Base went like this:

Bauers: "The thing that's following me... It's a big round flying aircraft of some sort. It fits the usual description of a UFO... Saucer shaped."

Pope AFB: "We've dropped him (from radar)... We're tracking only you now."

Bauers: "Of course you've only got one blip on your scope! He's so close to me we're printing (appearing) together!"

At this point, the air controller's voice at Pope became garbled. This was not

routine radio interference. Dick heard a faint, squeaking sound, then a series of hard, sporadic taps—like somebody banging the palm of his hand against a microphone. The featureless UFO was drawing even closer and Dick felt its behavior was hostile. He shut off his radio and concentrated on surviving.

For the next 17 minutes, Dick put his F-100 through wild, gyrating maneuvers, trying to shake off the mysterious intruder. Later, he would learn that people on the ground spotted the UFO. Bill Wright, assistant city editor of the *Fayetteville Observer*, recalled later that several persons telephoned to report the saucer, although the paper decided not to run the story. Maj. James Shenkum, at nearby Fort Bragg, believes that several Army men on a field exercise also spotted the object.

For Dick Bauers it was like being in a dogfight—and he was in several of them in Vietnam, 1968-70. As he turned, dived, and rolled violently, the UFO stayed with him—matching every maneuver. He was certain it was under intelligent control. Slammed around in his cockpit by brutal G-forces, sickened, drenched in sweat, Bauers couldn't seem to break free! Whatever controlled the UFO was persistent, quick-witted, and equipped with technology far superior to that of the F-100.

Finally, the UFO broke off. As suddenly as it had homed-in on him, the craft banked away and began to climb—receding into the night sky.

At his home base, Dick Bauers spoke

to his squadron duty officer and tried to "sell" an idea he would pursue diligently over the coming years—that UFOs were real, possibly hostile, certainly dangerous, and perhaps emissaries from an advanced civilization on another planet. He wanted the Air Force to investigate them. The duty officer located a manual explaining that project Blue Book had ended in 1969. The officer suggested that Dick "go home, have a stiff drink, and sleep it off."

This was the beginning of Richard Bauers' losing battle with "Operation Ridicule."

In February 1973, two months after the UFO dogfight, Bauers overheard a few enlisted men ridiculing him for "going crazy and chasing little green men from space." An officer visiting the base for a unit inspection had warned several men to "stay away from Bauers. He's been seeing hallucinations."

Other things were on Dick Bauers' mind during this period. He almost got married. He went on a brief squadron deployment to Europe. His brother Jim was hospitalized. Dick wasn't obsessed with UFOs and wasn't trying to "rock the boat" with his superior officers.

But there were several occasions when he argued about the UFO threat with superiors and each time was rebuffed. Dick formed the impression that the Air Force was secretly investigating UFOs, already knew something about the one he'd encountered, and didn't want him talking about it.

In mid-1973, Dick was transferred to a squadron in the midwest. On arrival, the executive officer shook his head and said, "Oh, you. You're the guy who spotted the UFO." It was the beginning of a bad relationship which rapidly got worse. Dick began getting extra duty

assignments which suggested that his new commanding officer, as well as the exec, regarded him with disfavor.

"You find out slowly when you're in trouble in an organization—whether it's a corporation or the Air Force. Nobody will actually come straight out and tell you. But the disapproval eventually becomes evident, and you start to notice that people won't take seriously anything you say, on any subject."

When his annual flight physical came due, the flight surgeon recommended an interview with a clinical psychologist—an unusual step; normally taken only when mental illness is suspected. Bauers went along with the interview and took a Rorschach inkblot test, but never learned why. "After some delay, during which time I was grounded; they told me I'd passed the test. But I was beginning to see a pattern. There were little things, like extra duty assignments which came out of turn. I was beginning to see that I was being needed, pestered, intimidated. It was a campaign to harass me, to make me feel insecure."



Dick had written, informally, to an old friend in the Pentagon with a low-key suggestion that the Air Force investigate UFOs openly. He was called on the carpet for it, and told it would show up unfavorably on his performance rating. It did. Although he was doing a first-rate job, he was "low-ranked" in his personnel report that year. His commanding officer hinted to him that he should leave the Air Force.

Dick asked for another tour in Southeast Asia but was refused—even though he was qualified and volunteers were needed. He was then slotted for a prestigious instructor's job in Arizona. It, too, was cancelled without explanation.

His girl friend at the time, Jerrie Hamlin, was visited by Air Force civilian investigators who wanted to know what Dick was "saying to people" about UFOs. Thinking she was being helpful, Jerrie pointed out that Dick had written to his Ohio congressman urging an open, public investigation. "They warned me against associating with him!" she said. "Can you imagine that? This was at the height of the Watergate era, and these gumshoes were telling me who I could associate with and who I couldn't!"

Three things happened in 1974 which altered Dick Bauers' perception of his life. He was passed over for major. The medics discovered a heart condition. And a very senior Air Force official warned him that he was "making waves" on the UFO issue.

This conversation with a member of the top brass is critical to the contention that Dick Bauers was a victim of "Operation Ridicule." I have reliable reports on this conversation from three independent sources, not counting Dick himself who told me of it in 1975. It took place in May 1974, at Scott Air Force Base in Belleville, Ill. (Dick was not stationed here at the time) and the four-star general is a very well-known officer whose name would be recognized immediately in military circles. I'm not naming him here because he has not responded to telephone and written requests for an interview.

Only days earlier, Dick had been warned that the angina condition discovered after a routine electrocardiogram might ground him. Summoned to meet the general, he flew a T-33 into Scott and appeared for the interview in flight fatigues.

This is what he was told: "Certain people" did not understand why he didn't get the message. Surely, a reasonable man would shut up about UFOs after being ridiculed as much as Dick had. Surely, a sensible man would know that there were career opportunities waiting to be grasped, if only the wave-making would stop.

It was a threat—clear and unmistakable. Delivered by a four-star general who gave the impression the whole U.S. government was behind him.

Dick didn't take the advice, continued speaking out on UFOs—and was separated from the service soon thereafter. A year later, we buried him.

I've known other victims of the Air Force's "Operation Ridicule" and two stand out in mind. One is Robert J. Pierson, of Sterling, Va., who retired from the Air Force as a major after seeking unsuccessfully for several years to arouse interest in a UFO he'd spotted. Pierson showed me his notes on conversations with senior officers who tried to harass, intimidate and ridicule him. A key piece of information from Pierson is that orders to harass him came from a small Air Force unit—purpose not known—located at the Navy base at Patuxent, Md. More on Patuxent in a moment.

A diminutive, 25-year-old filling station attendant has actually been challenging the Pentagon's top brass—defying Operation Ridicule—with his claim that he spotted UFOs while in the Air Force.

The battle of the Pentagon vs. Perkins—Air Force veteran George A. Perkins of Wheaton, Md.—revolves around the latter's efforts to reopen the official investigation of UFOs. "I saw intruders from space," Perkins says, referring to bizarre "flicker flashes" he spotted as a crew member on a C-130 transport.

Perkins knows numerous other cases where these small pinpoints of flashing light, or mini-UFO's, have been spotted by servicemen—and by Apollo 11 astronaut Edwin Aldrin. He says the Pentagon is directing a campaign to discredit his letters to congressmen and his other efforts to expose the UFO threat. The Air Force denies that it is harassing Perkins.

"I've got the evidence," he says. "I know a half dozen people who've been ruined by the Air Force's ridicule campaign. Sooner or later, I'm going to get some official recognition and a reversal of policy."

Where does "Operation Ridicule" originate? Who is in charge of this campaign to make life miserable for UFO witnesses, especially those military men who speak out? How far up does this cover-up go?

This has been the thorniest problem over the years for the serious UFO researcher. The trail is always well covered and the clues never lead to the culprit.

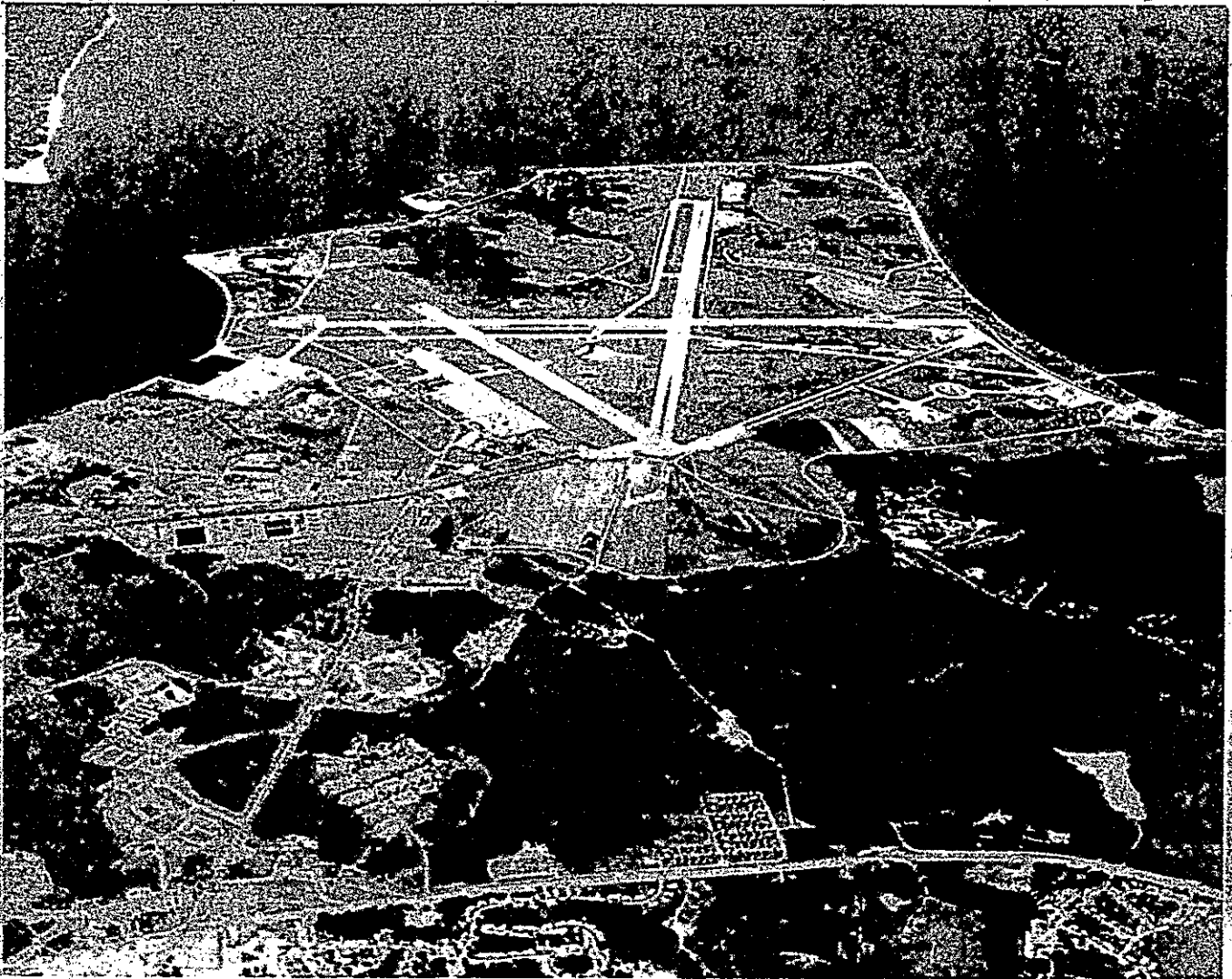
The evidence is strong that some secret office, somewhere near the top in the U.S. government, is overseeing a secret investigation of UFOs—and running "Operation Ridicule" to keep the public from finding out about it.

One of the nation's leading authorities on UFOs, whom I won't name, believes it's the CIA. Ralph Blum, co-author of *Beyond Earth: Man's Contact with UFOs*, believes it's a certain "Room 39" in the Pentagon. Donald Keyhoe believed that the secret office was located at Air Force headquarters at Bolling Field in Washington, D.C.

No one knows for sure.

I've uncovered several clues that suggest that America's secret UFO program—and the campaign to ridicule military personnel who've seen UFOs—is located in a fenced-in stucco building adjacent to the mud flats along Maryland's Patuxent River.

Here at the Patuxent Naval Air Test Center, a number of strange things are going on—Navy squadron VX(N)-8



At Patuxent Naval Air Test Center in Maryland, paranormal research is carried on in strict secrecy behind barbed wire fences. UFO's, the Bermuda Triangle, and bizarre experiments to contact extraterrestrials are the concern of a select military group who are suspected of coordinating *Operation Ridicule*.

operating a fleet of P-3 Orion electronics aircraft to investigate mysterious phenomena in the world's oceans, an Air Force radar surveillance outfit reporting *directly* to the Pentagon (!), and a cluster of civilian-garbed Air Force intelligence people (on a Navy base!) are all working behind those high mesh fences in a top security area. "This is the headquarters for it all," a naval officer once told me. "The UFO investigation, the research on the Bermuda Triangle, even experiments aimed at making contact with intelligent life in the universe. There's a guy in charge, in that building, who reports directly to the top."

I discovered that several persons identified with "Operation Ridicule" are also linked to the supersecret Patuxent facility. There was that assertion from Major Pierson that orders to harass him came from a Navy base in Maryland. Also, when Dick Bauers tried to learn the name of the officer visiting his unit for inspection—the man who'd told

others to stay away from him—Dick was told the man had departed on a VIP aircraft for *Patuxent*. Coincidence?

These "leads" are circumstantial. Although Capt. Charles R. Gillespie, the commander at Patuxent, couldn't be interviewed, his public affairs officer, W. M. Frierson, Jr., denied that any UFO-related activity is taking place there. In fact, any other base—or CIA headquarters at Langley, Va., or the Pentagon—might as easily be suspect.

The likely truth is that any national UFO cover-up, if there is one, probably involves all the services and several government agencies in different locations. This is strong talk, and over the years that UFOs have been of interest, no one has ever proved that any such widespread conspiracy exists. Even the most ardent UFO believers have difficulty explaining how such a big secret could be held, so tightly, for so many

years, by so many people.

There is, of course, a far more credible explanation for "Operation Ridicule." It's called *CYA*. This is the theory that the Air Force is hypersensitive to any unfavorable publicity, wants to protect its image, and therefore must ease out of the service any personnel who might cause public-relations problems. Under this theory, the Air Force could be actively campaigning to ridicule UFO witnesses *even if it has no other interest in UFOs*. *CYA*, of course, means cover your arse.

The trouble with this "protect your image" theory is that it doesn't answer some nagging questions. Why did Dick Bauers get the impression that the Air Force *already knew* about the UFO he'd seen? Why are mysterious people coming and going from the Patuxent installation? Why all the secret activity?

Some of these questions can only be answered by the men behind "Operation Ridicule"—and so far, they aren't talking. ★